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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Trump to drop push for Guard

Deployment in cities met legal challenges at nearly every turn

By Michelle L. Price
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump said he’s dropping — for now — his push to deploy National Guard troops in Chicago, Los Angeles and Portland, Oregon, a move that comes after legal roadblocks hung up the effort.

In a social media post, Trump announced he was removing the Guard troops, but added: “We will come back, perhaps in a much different and stronger form, when crime begins to soar again - Only a question of time!”

Troops had already left Los Angeles after the president deployed them earlier this year as part of a broader crackdown on crime and immigration. They had been sent to Chicago and Portland but were never on the streets as legal challenges played out.

In a statement on Wednesday afternoon, Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson reiterated that Trump’s effort to deploy National Guard troops to the city’s streets was “both unnecessary and unconstitutional,” adding that Chicago’s number of homicides has dropped significantly.

“In the new year, we will continue to resist federal overreach while focusing on the strategies that work to drive down crime and violence,” Johnson said.

The president has made a crackdown on crime in cities a centerpiece of his second term — and has toyed with the idea of invoking the Insurrection Act to stop his opponents from

Turn to *Troops*, Page 5

“I think people should be concerned. I don’t think influenza is ever something to scoff at. I think people tend to think of the flu as something that’s just another cough and cold. Certainly, while most people won’t get that sick from influenza ... the risk of hospitalization and complications is nontrivial.”

— Dr. Larry Kocielek, an attending physician of pediatric infectious disease at Lurie Children’s Hospital



Dr. Jasmine Saavedra examines 10-month-old Renata García near her mother, Lety Ixquereu, at the Esperanza Health Centers’ Brighton Park North Clinic on Wednesday. Renata was diagnosed with the flu during her last visit to the health center. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Flu taking winter toll

Health officials urge vaccines as surge cuts into holiday revelry for many

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

Tom Tassoni’s winter break has been filled with fevers, coughing, soup and Gatorade — times five.

Flu-like symptoms hit the Oak Lawn dad’s 4-year-old daughter about a week before Christmas and soon spread to him, his wife and their two toddlers. They’re just now starting to emerge from

the fog of sickness.

“It was a rough Christmas,” Tassoni said. “We’ve just kind of been laid up.”

Across the Chicago area and the country, people have increasingly been coming down with the flu in recent weeks. Flu activity officially jumped to high levels in suburban Cook County, and emergency department visits and hospitalizations for the flu were

high in Chicago for the week that ended Dec. 20, according to the county and city health departments.

Chicago-area hospitals say they’ve seen spikes in patients with the flu. Emergency room visits related to the flu nearly tripled in suburban Cook County during the week that ended Dec. 20, said Dr. Kiran Joshi, Cook County Department of Public

Health chief operating officer.

Nationally, flu activity is high or very high in more than half of states, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. In Illinois, flu activity was moderate for the week that ended Dec. 20, according to the state health department.

While it’s not unusual for flu

Turn to *Flu*, Page 4



LEAFING AN IMPRESSION

Chicago-based Farmer’s Fridge has turned vending machine salad into fast-food success

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

When Luke Saunders came up with the novel idea to sell salads from a vending machine 12 years ago, it was so far out of the box that he had to invent a new one.

Believing that fast food should be faster and healthier, Saunders dreamed up the concept of Farmer’s Fridge without a blueprint on how to do it. For starters, vending machines, which had long dispensed chips, candy bars and sodas to snacking office workers, simply weren’t set up to

deliver fresh salads on demand.

So Saunders, then a recent college graduate and novice entrepreneur, created a prototype, stuffed it with fresh greens, stuck it in a downtown Chicago food court and launched the salad vending company in October 2013.

“When I started back then, I probably didn’t sleep for a month because I had spent my life savings on a vending machine, and I had to figure out by launching it if people were going to sign

Turn to *Salad*, Page 2

Farmer’s Fridge CEO Luke Saunders, top, stands at the company headquarters in Chicago. DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

After delay, renovation of Capitol nears end

\$350M update stalled due to harsh weather

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — It’s been about four years since construction crews began ripping through the north end of the 19th-century Illinois Capitol, the historic building’s latest modernization, which will include updated offices and enhanced security, as well as a refurbished Senate chamber finished last year.

The \$350 million project, the second major overhaul of the Capitol in just over a decade, is about seven or eight months from completion, according to Andrea



The new entrance under construction at the Illinois Capitol building in Springfield in 2023. TERENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Aggertt, the Capitol architect overseeing the work. The renovation encompasses the building’s north wing, a new underground conference center and parking garage, extensive structural upgrades and a reimagined main entrance for visitors.

It was originally expected to wrap up last year. But delays — many tied to harsh winter conditions — have slowed progress.

“Mother Nature has not been

kind to us recently,” Aggertt said during an interview with the Tribune in mid-December on a cold, gray, windy day on the construction site, as it was covered in mud with sprinkles of leftover snow. “We’ve had people get stuck. Difficulty in getting material back to the building. The cold weather, it slows work down outside and also on the inside.”

Turn to *Capitol*, Page 4

CHICAGOLAND As ACA subsidies end, costs to rise

With health care subsidies expiring in the new year, Cook County Health officials and political leaders on Wednesday warned the impact will not only hurt millions of Americans but also affect the county’s bottom line and hospitals around the state.



CHRIS SWEDA/TRIBUNE

CHICAGO SPORTS Williams rewrites Bears’ QB history

Caleb Williams knew what he signed up for when he came to Chicago, where “quarterbacks go to die.” But when the Bears face the Lions on Sunday at Soldier Field, Williams will be staring down a chance to become the first 4,000-yard passer in franchise history.

